Small Garden Watering

Observing soil

Check the soil before watering a container garden. Push a finger about two centimeters into the soil. If the soil feels dry at that depth, the container needs water. If the soil feels moist, wait and check again later. The surface alone can look dry while the soil below is still moist.

Watering slowly

Apply water slowly near the soil surface. Slow watering gives water time to soak into the soil rather than run over the edge of the container. Stop when water begins to leave the drainage holes. A container without drainage holes can retain excess water around roots.

Keeping a record

A simple watering record contains the date, the soil observation, and the action taken. For example, a gardener might write: Monday, dry at two centimeters, watered slowly. The record helps the gardener compare observations over several days. It does not establish a universal watering schedule.

Changing conditions

A container may dry faster on a warm, windy day than on a cool, still day. Container size and the amount of direct sunlight can also affect how quickly the soil dries. Use soil observations to decide whether to water instead of assuming every container needs water on the same day.

Comparing two containers

Suppose Container A feels dry at two centimeters and Container B feels moist at the same depth. Based on these observations, water Container A slowly and wait before watering Container B. Record each observation and action separately. This comparison uses the observations rather than a fixed calendar rule.